magnificent temples, including the famous Vaikuntha Perumal in Kanchipuram. Hinduism has been strengthened by its imports too.

HINDUISM AND SCIENCE

Similar battles are being waged over other kinds of intellectual terrain, with Hindu nationalists insisting upon recognising the glories of ancient Indian thought and long-neglected ancestral accomplishments, notably in science. There is definitely a case for enhancing the Indian public's awareness of the genuinely impressive accomplishments of their forebears (of which more below), rather than remaining schooled in a colonial-era Westernised view of the world. But the uncritical, indeed fantasy-laden, manner in which its Hindutva aficionados have advocated the cause has only discredited it.

The dominance of the BJP at the centre and in the states has propelled a number of true believers of Hindutva into positions of unprecedented influence, including in such forums[9] as the Indian Council for Historical Research, the University Grants Commission, and, it turned out, the programme committee of the Indian Science Congress, which scheduled a talk on 'Vedic Aviation Technology' in 2015 that elicited howls of protest from many delegates.

It has also given a licence to unqualified voices who gain in authority from their proximity to power. The 2018 statement by India's junior education Minister, Satyapal Singh, that Darwin's theory of evolution was "unscientific"—on the grounds that "no one has ever seen an ape turn into a man"—drew attention to the latest challenge posed to modern India by its current government. Earlier, another BJP stalwart, Rajasthan's education minister Vasudev Devnani, had dealt science another body blow by claiming that the cow is something of an obsession for the BJP, whose followers have assaulted human beings in the name of cow protection, but this was a step too far even for many of its sympathisers among the educated public.

The two Ministers are educated men: Satyapal Singh is a chemistry graduate, and Vasudev Devnani is a trained engineer. Whether their statements reveal the quality of science education in India, or merely confirm that Hindutva ideology trumps both scientific fact and common